

**Medford School Committee
Curriculum Subcommittee Notes
Meeting via Zoom: November 18, 2020**

Meeting Purpose: To Address Disability Awareness In MPS Curriculum

Paulette Van der Kloot, Chair, present
Jenny Graham, member present
Mea Mustone, member, absent
Paul Ruseau will be attending in her place

Jenny Graham: taking the roll:

Jenny Graham: Here; Paulette Van der Kloot: Here; Mea: Absent; Paul Ruseau: Here

Tonya Sullivan and Alex Lauric co-chairs from Medford SEPAC

Alex Lauric: Co-chair, parent of a 6th grader with intellectual disabilities presenting their work on a Disability Awareness Curriculum. SEPAC has been working on adoption of a disability awareness in MPS since 2016

Advocating for 20% of MPS Students

Suzannah Campbell has been conducting Disability Awareness training for teachers.

Implementation: goal of teaching 2-3 units per grade as part of the ELA curriculum. Materials to be identified at the district level.

Conclusion: Introducing a disability awareness curriculum in MPS is a priority for SEPAC.

Paulette Van der Kloot: thank you to Alex, Tonya and SEPAC for taking the initiative on this.

Joan Bowen and Suzannah Campbell presenting Disability Awareness in the Classroom
[Link to Presentation here](#)

Suzannah Campbell is presenting an overview of the course she ran last year and next steps for this Spring (Jan2021). This PD is available on the PD website and is open for registration. Open to all staff. Whole school, not just Teachers. Thursday afternoons 3:15 to 5:15 in January and February via zoom.

Outcomes for the Course: history of disabilities in US, legislation, Bias,
Ableism: belief in our society that not being disabled is the norm,
Disability Etiquette: teachers can model disability etiquette. Asking person if they want assistance rather than stepping in, unique needs of students with various disabilities, literature with positive representations of PWD, Tools to break down stereotypes

Key Curricular Concepts:

- Positive representation of PWD in content area lessons
- Universal design for learning helps all have better access
- Ant-ableism language practices into content area lessons
- Reframe misconceptions
- Building a more inclusive environment
- Creating a community

Next Steps (Joan Bowen)

PD Course (jan/feb 2021)

Recruit volunteers to pilot a disability awareness curriculum in Feb. 2021, and then pilot in the classrooms March - May 2021

Not a one and one. Want this to be embedded into everyday instruction.
We had a huge turnout in 2019 for the pd. Excited to do it again and begin the pilot process.

Suzannah Campbell: showed some lessons that came out of the course:

Out of my mind lesson plan (5th grade teacher at McGlynn)

Book focused on an intermediate grade student who is unable to speak. Incorporated the Curriculum Framework standards while also brought into disability awareness

Out of this course, they created a Disability Awareness Drive to share lesson plans to share lesson plans by grade and content area.

Paulette Van der Kloot: How many teachers took the course last time?

Suzannah Campbell: about 48. I don't know how many we will get this year. Hoping 15-20 this year. People are very overwhelmed this year. We will continue this the following year to catch even more people to share the work further.

Paulette Van der Kloot: I love seeing these lesson plans. I am concerned that a student might not get through all 8 grades without seeing any of this material.

Suzannah Campbell: Agree - this has been on a volunteer basis but need to have goals by grade level, addressing different topics as students move through grades.

Jenny Graham: Did we make a conscious decision to build it over time instead of purchasing a curriculum that is all done. Was the point of the PD for teachers to build their own stuff?
What research did we do to decide that we were not to buy anything?

Suzannah Campbell: Going back to conversations with Kathy Medaglio. Buying something would make it one and done instead of educating the teachers as well. Important to inform our staff about the concept of ableism.

Jenny Graham: The PD piece is different from the curriculum piece. How do we make sure we have scope and sequences for all the topics that need to be covered.

Understanding our Differences is a boxed curriculum

Alex Lauric: Sepac did that research on different packages that explore disabilities. UOD was the closest. Each topic is presented in two hours. SEPAC is hoping to see better integration of the concepts and decided that creating something new would be better. UOD only deals with elementary school.

Melanie McLaughlin: Speaking as a parent and as former co-chair of SEPAC.

Kathy Medaglio and SEPAC have been working on this for a long time. It was purchased for 5th grade at Brooks but it was never implemented. It was very expensive, \$1500 for the one unit. This has been an evolution of the last five years to develop work.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Is Out of My Mind a required 5th grade book?

Suzannah Campbell: Not aligned with Journeys. It was a novel of the teacher's choice. Lists of books have been compiled and books were purchased by the librarians. If we want to select specific books, then we need to do that work and talk about it. We have not taken that step as of yet.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Is there a way to suggest to other teachers who have not done the training that they might want to use the lesson plans that these teachers have created. How do we encourage all teachers to consider? Can we send out a couple of lesson plans for each grade? How do we ramp it up a little bit more?

Suzannah Campbell: In second grade Journeys, there is a story about blindness and Braille. We need to talk to Dr. Chiesa about choosing literature that works towards the goals of disability awareness.

Jenny Graham: Are there contractual levers that would make this PD required by a certain time? It is voluntary at the moment. Going from something that is voluntary vs. something that is mandatory.

Suzannah Campbell: It depends on the priorities of the time and the year. There is mandatory PD each year but it varies depending on the situation. This PD happens after school hours so cannot make it mandatory because it is not in contract.

Joan Bowen: Teachers need so many PDPs on special ed for licensure. We can promote it to staff because it will fulfill that requirement. Teachers can share what they learned in their PLCs to share the knowledge through their buildings.

Suzanne Galusi: We are starting with the pilot and growing from there. Goal is for every single educator to be part of the training. PLCs, using common planning time are ways of delivering this to everybody.

Jenny Graham: Re the ELA curriculum, this committee has a goal of auditing our curricula. We could use this lens when looking at the current ELA curriculum. There may be nuggets in the Journeys curriculum but maybe not enough.

Paulette Van der Kloot: we also need to look at the racial equity piece

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: I am happy there is not a canned curriculum because we need a true mindshift in this area: not just checking a box. Making intentional connections is healthier for students. Letting it happen organically is the best way to bring about authentic change. We got such valuable feedback from the first session. I know many people are waiting to join next session. We could look at targeting a grade level. It should not be one more thing to be added on. It is an extension of the current work. If it is incorporated well, it won't feel like an add-on.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Any teachers from MVTHS?

Suzannah Campbell: Not that I can remember. We had a variety including paras and admin. We had teachers Pre-k through high school

Paulette Van der Kloot: How do we make sure our staff is knowledgeable about the disabilities our students have?

Suzannah Campbell: Two pronged course: one is about teaching students; other part is teaching the teachers to use Universal Design to help them become more knowledgeable about disabilities. There is a lot of background knowledge provided to teachers: students with or without IEPs and 504s who may have disabilities.

Paulette Van der Kloot: When we have students with disabilities, we have many consultations with teachers about accommodations to inform the teachers about their students. We offer that ongoing support to the teachers when it comes to learning about their students.

Alex Lauric: Will there be a report at the end of the year so we can learn about next steps?

Paulette Van der Kloot: I agree with that question. How can we evaluate implementation?

Suzannah Campbell: we need to id the teachers who will be piloting the lesson plans. We need to support that learning community to assess what is being done at their grade level and what can be substituted.

Paulette Van der Kloot: How many teachers are you thinking?

Suzannah Campbell: I will see how many teachers volunteer? I am open to 3 or more different grade levels.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Let's touch back on this either at the end of the year or very beginning of next year.

Suzannah Campbell: Having a report for you in June makes sense.

Alex Lauric: In summer 2019, you had a grant for adaptive books workshop. Maybe over the summer, teachers who are interested in this might want to pursue this work.

Suzannah Campbell: it does overlap nicely with this work. I don't know if we have the grant funding but I will look into it for you.

Paulette Van der Kloot: There are budgetary implications. If there are materials and books needed, it would be great to know about it before budget time.

Paul Ruseau: PTOs are sources of massive inequality. If we look to the PTO to fund any of this, I do not support it.

Melanie McLaughlin: Funds from the Brooks PTO did provide adaptive books for all the schools. I appreciate PR's position on that.

Paul Ruseau: that sharing is wonderful but the SC cant vote to supporting something without putting a line item for it in the budget.

Jenny Graham: I make a motion to reconvene and address the budgetary items come to us regarding disability awareness prior to budget season.

ROLL: two affirmative one absent motion passes.

Joan Bowen: that can be done.

Tonya Sullivan: Thank you for the opportunity to present this today.

Paulette Van der Kloot thank you to the SEPAC and the Special Ed department for all the work that has been done on this.

Next meeting December 10 - looking at Math.

Motion to adjourn the meeting. 5:04. Ending early.